

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Hairdressing and Barbering English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Hairstylists, barbers, salon assistants, and salon reception staff.

All clients, prices, timings, products, and incidents are fictional English practice. This course is not training in cutting, shaving, chemical services, infection control, or diagnosis. Technical suitability and any health concern require the appropriately qualified professional and applicable local procedures. Sample salon policies are not universal rules.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Turning a reference photo into a clear request

Resolve conflicting length preferences before a haircut.

02 Describing shape, texture, and everyday styling

Use the same appearance and routine criteria for two styles.

03 Discussing color without promising a photograph

Describe a color preference while preserving genuine uncertainty.

04 Booking time and handling appointment changes

Negotiate appointments without disguising a timing conflict.

05 Checking comfort and pausing clearly

Ask a specific comfort question and acknowledge the answer.

06 Explaining services, prices, and product choices

Separate included services from optional additions.

07 Responding to a concern about the result

Repair an expectation mismatch without arguing or inventing a solution.

08 Passing preferences to the next appointment

Give a concise handover with an identifiable next task.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Turning a reference photo into a clear request

Resolve conflicting length preferences before a haircut.

CASE

A client shows a chin-length bob but wants to keep enough length for a low ponytail. No cut has started. The photo has a straight fringe; the client has not requested one. Clarify which features matter and confirm a collarbone-length outline.

Teach this move

A photograph contains several choices. Separate length, outline, and fringe; use an indirect question to find the feature the client means.

Vocabulary to check: consultation, reference photo, perimeter, fringe.

Model response

Your photo has a shorter outline and a straight fringe, but keeping a low ponytail matters to you. Which feature of the photo do you want to keep? We can discuss a collarbone-length outline instead. Before we start, please confirm whether you want any change around your forehead.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised response checks individual choices instead of assuming every detail is wanted.

Second-round challenge

The client points to the fringe while saying 'this shape.' Ask whether the gesture changes the earlier preference.

Language-check answers

1. C - which feature you want to copy Correct. The indirect question uses subject before verb.
2. B - fringe Correct. A fringe falls across the forehead.

05 • Conversations

1. A bob photograph with a ponytail requirement - A first consultation before any cutting.

2. What does a tidy-up include? - A barber clarifies a returning client's brief request.

3. Bangs and fringe mean the same area - A visitor uses a different regional word at the salon.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two photographs, one preferred feature

A client brings one photo for the back outline and another for the long front. Both show shorter overall hair than the client wants. The client needs shoulder length.

Role A: Stylist: identify one feature from each photo and confirm the retained length.

Role B: Client: choose the rounded back from photo A and long front from photo B; reject their overall length.

Possible opening: Can I combine the back from this picture with the front from that one?

Success checks

- Identify the chosen feature in each photo.
- Confirm shoulder length independently of the photographs.
- Restate the combined request aloud before proceeding.

Add a complication: The client calls both pictures 'the shorter one.' Ask them to point to A or B.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Describing shape, texture, and everyday styling

Use the same appearance and routine criteria for two styles.

CASE

A client wants less fullness at the neckline but does not want exposed skin at the sides. Photo A, labelled 'low taper,' shows visible hair covering the sides. Photo B, labelled 'skin fade,' shows exposed skin at the shortest area of the sides. The client spends five minutes styling each morning. Compare these supplied appearances, not cutting methods or guaranteed upkeep.

Teach this move

Names alone do not fix an exact length. Compare what is visible in the supplied images, then check the client's priorities without teaching a cutting method.

Vocabulary to check: taper, fade, layers, natural texture.

Model response

In these photos, the low taper keeps more visible hair at the sides, whereas the skin fade exposes skin at the shortest area. You said you want less fullness at the neckline without that exposed look. Let's discuss the taper image as a reference and check how it fits your usual five-minute routine.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The comparison identifies an observable difference instead of an unexplained ranking.

Second-round challenge

The client assumes 'low' means the same length in both photos. Clarify the actual area being compared.

Language-check answers

1. B - whereas Correct. 'Whereas' contrasts the two appearances.
2. A - natural texture Correct. This refers to the usual curl pattern.

05 · Conversations

1. Covered sides or a skin-level finish? - A barber compares two reference images with a client.
2. Layers without losing the outer length - A salon consultation separates internal shape from the outside outline.
3. The finish should reflect the usual curls - A client asks about a style photographed on straightened hair.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A beard photograph with an unfamiliar label

A client requests a 'fade' after seeing a beard photograph. They mean a softer transition at the sideburns, not a shorter beard overall. The client likes the current chin length.

Role A: Barber: distinguish sideburn appearance from overall beard length.

Role B: Client: protect the chin length and point to the transition in the photograph.

Possible opening: When I say fade, I mean this part near my ears.

Success checks

- Identify the actual area in the photo.
- Keep overall beard length separate from the transition.
- Confirm appearance preferences without explaining tool techniques.

Add a complication: The client asks whether the service name alone guarantees the pictured result.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Discussing color without promising a photograph

Describe a color preference while preserving genuine uncertainty.

CASE

A client wants the cool tone in a photograph before Friday. Their previous home color product is unknown. Today's booking is a consultation only; suitability, service time, and cost have not been assessed.

Teach this move

A target shade is a request, not evidence of suitability. Identify missing history and keep the consultation separate from a service booking.

Vocabulary to check: regrowth, tone, highlight, color history.

Model response

The photograph helps us discuss the cool tone you prefer, but it doesn't establish what we can achieve by Friday. Your previous color product is still unknown. Today is a consultation; we need to review your color history before confirming a service, timing, or price.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision preserves the preference without promising a technical outcome.

Second-round challenge

The client says the photograph proves it is possible in one visit. Explain the limit of that evidence.

Language-check answers

1. A - unconfirmed Correct. The outcome has not been established.
2. D - tone Correct. Golden describes warm tone.

05 • Conversations

1. A Friday target is not a confirmed result - A client attends a color consultation.
2. Warmth is not the same as darkness - A client compares two salon shade samples.

3. Remembering the missing appointment history - A stylist asks a returning client about an incomplete record.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A highlight request becomes an all-over question

A client booked a consultation about a few lighter sections but now wants the whole head to match a pale photograph. No service has been booked.

Role A: Stylist: distinguish selected highlights from the new overall request.

Role B: Client: want the pale appearance but cannot provide previous product details.

Possible opening: Does asking for highlights mean the whole head will look like this?

Success checks

- Separate highlighted sections from the all-over request.
- Identify the missing history.
- Keep service price and consultation price distinct.

Add a complication: The client assumes the consultation price is the price of either service.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Booking time and handling appointment changes

Negotiate appointments without disguising a timing conflict.

CASE

A haircut appointment at 2:00 is running twenty minutes late. The usual service duration is forty minutes. The client must leave by 2:45. A 10:00 appointment tomorrow is available; the stylist cannot promise a shortened service today. This salon waives the change fee when its delay causes this rescheduling.

Teach this move

State the delay and the client's departure separately. A shorter remaining window does not make the service itself shorter.

Vocabulary to check: walk-in, appointment slot, waiting list, service duration.

Model response

We're twenty minutes behind, and the usual forty-minute service would take us past your 2:45 departure. I can't promise to compress it into that time. Tomorrow at ten is available. Would you prefer that appointment, or to discuss another time that gives you the full slot?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The client can choose using an honest time comparison.

Second-round challenge

The client offers to skip the consultation. Keep the complete appointment's timing and assessment needs clear.

Language-check answers

1. D - 3:00 Correct. Forty minutes after 2:20 is 3:00.
2. C - contact you Correct. A waiting list offers contact if space opens.

05 • Conversations

1. The departure time cannot move - Reception discusses the delayed 2:00 haircut.

2. A walk-in between booked clients - A barber explains current availability to a visitor.

3. An offer is not a booking - A salon receptionist calls a client on the waiting list.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two people, one online appointment

Two friends arrive under one forty-minute haircut booking. Only one service is reserved. A second full slot is available at five; the friends cannot both stay until then.

Role A: Receptionist: explain what is booked and offer a separate slot.

Role B: Client: keep your appointment; your friend can come tomorrow at noon, which is also open.

Possible opening: We put both our names in the note, so are both haircuts included?

Success checks

- Distinguish a note from a second booking.
- Do not halve the service time as an automatic solution.
- Confirm separate appointments and names aloud.

Add a complication: The client asks to divide the forty minutes equally.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Checking comfort and pausing clearly

Ask a specific comfort question and acknowledge the answer.

CASE

Before a wash, a client says the neck support feels uncomfortable. Water has not started. Ask the client to describe the pressure, pause preparation, and arrange a comfort check. Do not diagnose the discomfort or prescribe a position.

Teach this move

Invite a description rather than a yes-or-no endorsement. A comfort check is not a diagnosis or a technical treatment instruction.

Vocabulary to check: cape, shampoo basin, neck support, sensitivity.

Model response

Please tell me where the support feels uncomfortable before we begin. We haven't started the water, and I'll pause here while we check the arrangement with you. You don't need to put up with discomfort to keep the appointment moving. Let me know whether you want to leave the basin.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The open question does not pressure the client to agree.

Second-round challenge

The client apologizes for slowing the appointment. Acknowledge the concern without minimizing the discomfort.

Language-check answers

1. C - pause Correct. 'Pause' means temporarily stop.
2. B - Around Correct. 'Around' describes the cape surrounding the neck.

05 • Conversations

1. Pressure before the water starts - A stylist checks a client's comfort at the basin.
2. A cape that catches on a collar - A barber responds to a client's comfort request.
3. A fragrance preference is not a diagnosis - A client asks about a strongly scented styling product.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A quieter consultation

A client says the music makes the consultation hard to hear. A quieter chair is available, and reception can lower the music in the consultation area.

Role A: Stylist: offer the quieter chair and repeat the length request.

Role B: Client: prefer to move and want to see the stylist's face during discussion.

Possible opening: Could we go somewhere quieter before deciding on the length?

Success checks

- Do not treat the earlier nod as agreement.
- Offer the stated quieter option.
- Repeat and confirm the actual haircut preference.

Add a complication: The client nodded earlier but now says they missed the question.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Explaining services, prices, and product choices

Separate included services from optional additions.

CASE

The fictional menu lists a haircut at \$45 and an optional finish at \$15, with no other charges in this exercise. A client thinks \$45 includes the finish. Neither service has begun. Explain the \$60 combined total and the \$45 haircut-only choice.

Teach this move

Use a clear breakdown and ask for a choice. Avoid treating interest in an add-on as agreement to pay for it.

Vocabulary to check: service menu, starting price, add-on, itemized receipt.

Model response

The forty-five-dollar price covers the haircut; the finish is an optional fifteen-dollar addition. Together they would be sixty dollars, with no other charges. You can choose the haircut alone for forty-five. Which option would you like me to confirm before we begin?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The client can compare complete amounts.

Second-round challenge

The client asks whether buying a product makes the finish free. No such offer exists in the supplied menu.

Language-check answers

1. B - optional Correct. The client may choose or decline it.
2. A - is optional and separately charged Correct. Declining the separately priced finish leaves the haircut-only choice available.

05 • Conversations

1. The finish is a separate choice - A stylist explains a fictional menu before starting: haircut forty-five dollars, optional finish fifteen, and no additional charges.

2. A starting price needs a specific estimate - A client phones about a service menu.
3. A product quantity is not a discount - A client compares two sizes of styling cream.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A beard service was not included

The haircut price is \$30; a beard trim is separately listed at \$12. The client requested both verbally but no total was agreed. Neither has started.

Role A: Barber: explain the \$42 combined price and the \$30 alternative.

Role B: Client: have a \$35 budget and prefer the haircut today.

Possible opening: I thought the beard trim came with the haircut.

Success checks

- Use the supplied prices only.
- Confirm the haircut-only choice.
- Do not imply the declined service will happen anyway.

Add a complication: The client asks whether a shorter beard trim has an unpublished lower price.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Responding to a concern about the result

Repair an expectation mismatch without arguing or inventing a solution.

CASE

A client says the left side looks longer. The earlier explanation promised an even outline, but the current appearance has not been reviewed together. Pause checkout, acknowledge the concern, and offer mirror review with the stylist. No correction or refund has been approved.

Teach this move

Repeat the client's observation accurately. Discuss a review before promising an adjustment, price reduction, or particular result.

Vocabulary to check: adjustment, service review, asymmetry, goodwill gesture.

Model response

You were expecting an even outline, and you're noticing a longer-looking section on the left. I'm sorry this hasn't been addressed before checkout. Let's look at the area together with the stylist. We haven't agreed on an adjustment or refund yet; first we need to understand the specific concern.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The response takes the observation seriously without claiming its cause.

Second-round challenge

The client asks whether acknowledging the concern means the salon has approved a free adjustment.

Language-check answers

1. A - asymmetry Correct. The client describes a difference between sides.
2. D - service review Correct. A discussion is agreed, not a financial remedy.

05 • Conversations

1. The left side looks longer - A client raises a concern before checkout.
2. A blunt message needs a correction - A receptionist repairs an earlier response to a service query.
3. A concern after a different home finish - A client returns with a question about the haircut's appearance.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The requested parting was misunderstood

A client requested a left-side parting but sees a center parting in the finish. No additional cutting has happened. The stylist can review the request now.

Role A: Stylist: acknowledge the specific misunderstanding and invite review.

Role B: Client: want the left-side appearance, not a shorter cut.

Possible opening: I meant a parting on the left, not through the center.

Success checks

- Name the parting concern accurately.
- Do not turn it into a request to cut more hair.
- Confirm what the client wants reviewed.

Add a complication: A colleague assumes the complaint is about haircut length.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Passing preferences to the next appointment

Give a concise handover with an identifiable next task.

CASE

A client requests a future color consultation but has not booked it. Reception is taking over. Today's confirmed preferences are retained front length and no finishing spray. The client has not agreed to promotional photographs. Handover the preferences and unbooked request accurately.

Teach this move

Use past tense for today's confirmed choices and request language for future interest. A note is not a booking or permission for another purpose.

Vocabulary to check: client record, service note, rebooking, handover.

Model response

Today's preferences were to retain the front length and leave out finishing spray. The client asked about a future color consultation, but no date is booked. Please offer available consultation times and confirm the choice directly. There is no agreement to promotional photography, so the visit note should not imply permission.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The next worker knows which action is missing.

Second-round challenge

The client consents to an internal reference photo but not publication. Repeat the limited permission.

Language-check answers

1. D - inquired Correct. Asking about it does not establish a booking.
2. C - the stated record use Correct. Permission is limited to the described record use.

05 • Conversations

1. A color inquiry reaches reception - A stylist hands a client visit over to reception.

2. Keeping an internal photograph private - A stylist clarifies a client's limited photo permission.
3. A new barber checks an old note - A covering barber discusses a returning client's recorded preference.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A consultation time offered by voicemail

Reception offered Tuesday at noon but received no reply. The client arrives asking about a Friday slot instead; Friday at three is available.

Role A: Receptionist: distinguish the unaccepted Tuesday offer from a booking.

Role B: Client: prefer Friday at three and want confirmation by text.

Possible opening: Was Tuesday already booked just because you left that message?

Success checks

- Explain that suggested does not mean accepted.
- Confirm Friday at three directly.
- Keep the record clear about which offer was accepted.

Add a complication: A colleague's note says 'Tuesday suggested' without showing a response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Barbers, Hairstylists, and Cosmetologists

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/personal-care-and-service/barbers-hairstylists-and-cosmetologists.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Hairdressers, Hairstylists, and Cosmetologists

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/39-5012.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.